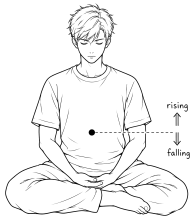
Sitting meditation

Watching the rise and fall of the abdomen, and noting whatever else takes the mind away from it.

1 · THE POSTURE

Sit on the floor with the legs crossed, one leg in front of the other rather than one on top of the other. Rest one hand on top of the other, palms up, in the lap. Keep the back straight, though it does not have to be rigid. Close the eyes.

A chair or a bench works just as well. Sit toward the front of the seat with both feet flat on the floor, and keep the back upright and away from the backrest. If you cannot sit up at all, the same practice can be done lying down.



One leg in front of the other, not on top of it. Attention stays on the abdomen.



On a chair, the instructions are unchanged.

2 · THE PRACTICE

Place the attention on the abdomen. Breathe normally. Do not deepen, slow or control the breath in any way. You are watching the breathing, not doing it.

As the abdomen rises, note silently in the mind: *rising*. As it falls, note: *falling*. Keep the note in time with the movement, so the word and the sensation happen together, not one before the other.

Carry on this way, *rising*, *falling*, *rising*, *falling*. This is the home base of the practice. You return to it every time you leave it.

3 · WHEN SOMETHING ELSE TAKES YOUR ATTENTION

The mind will not stay on the abdomen, and it is not supposed to. When something else becomes prominent, leave the abdomen and note what is actually there instead. Repeat the note until the thing fades, then go back to rising and falling. The note is a label, not a judgement: you are naming what is present, not approving of it, arguing with it, or trying to make it stop.

Thinking. Any thought at all, about the past or the future, pleasant or unpleasant, useful or trivial, gets the same note: *thinking*, *thinking*, *thinking*. You do not need to look at the content of the thought.

Body. When a sensation becomes stronger than the breath, note it where it is felt. Pain is the common one: note *pain*, *pain*, *pain* and keep noting until it subsides. Do not shift position at the first discomfort, and do not force yourself to sit through real injury.

Feeling and states of mind. Pleasant states get noted like everything else: *happy* when happiness arises, *calm* or *peaceful* when the mind settles. Calm is not the goal of the practice and is not a sign that you are doing it correctly. It is simply another thing to be aware of.

The same rule covers whatever else comes up: *liking*, *disliking*, *angry*, *bored*, *frustrated*, *lazy*, *drowsy*, *distracted*, *worried*, *doubting*, *confused*. Name it, keep naming it until it passes, then return to the abdomen.

4 · HOW LONG

Five to ten minutes is enough at the start. Lengthen it as your capacity grows, rather than by deciding in advance to endure more. Sitting is normally done after walking, and for the same length of time: ten minutes of walking followed by ten minutes of sitting.

If you cannot find the rising and falling. place a hand on the abdomen until the movement becomes clear, then take the hand away. If the movement is genuinely not there, note *sitting* instead, along with the touch of the body against the floor or the chair.

THE NOTES

rising	*falling*
thinking	*pain*
happy	*calm*
peaceful	*liking*
disliking	*angry*
bored	*drowsy*
distracted	*worried*
doubting	*sitting*

These instructions follow the meditation manual of Yuttadhammo Bhikkhu. The technique is the style of insight practice as taught by Ajahn Tong Sirimangalo, in which experience is noted silently and in plain language as it occurs.